Stolen Moments

By Janet O'Neill

I've gotten used to the snickers. The whispering. The name calling. The seven-year-old girl who just points and says Mommy! Look! I know Ricky and I are a scandal. Still, it stuns me when a woman approaches me at a restaurant and says:

WOMAN: Didn't know you liked dark meat.

What do you say? Well, actually I'm a vegetarian? It never works. So I smile. Shake my head. And return to my seat. Skin pigment. It can be hell.

INTRODUCTION

In 1967 the Supreme Court ruled in Loving v. Virginia that marriage bans between whites and blacks was unconstitutional, but before that interracial marriages were illegal in 16 states.

By 1995 interracial marriages were more common and far more accepted than they had ever been. But that didn't always make it easy.

1995: The year a jury found OJ Simpson "not guilty" for the murder of his ex-wife Nicole. Seinfeld was the most popular television show on 1 of the only 3 major networks.

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And Men were from Mars and Women from Venus. Black and white relationships were no longer taboo . . . But Susan's family and friends still had some issues.

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Ricky and I met at the Wash-n-Save Laundromat. He had this aloof look, like nothing could touch him and yet a magnetic charm that made you want to try. Our first conversation was pretty ironic:

SUSAN: Hey, I don't think you want to do that

RICKY: Do what?

SUSAN: Well, you need to separate your clothes. You're mixing your white and your coloreds.

After dating for a few months, the mixing of the colors and the whites had taken on a much deeper meaning. No one approved. A glare from the parking attendant. A reprimand from my aunt:

AUNT: That's fine if you want to mix for a while, but always meet in a public place. Nothing gets stolen that way, dear.

And of course, there was the resonating response from my father:

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FATHER: I don't have anything against Blacks. I think everyone ought to own one.

I kept using the line: It's 1995. People aren't going to tolerate that racist talk. Never seemed to make a difference.

Ricky and I didn't date on the assumption that we'd act like we're colorblind. Race ***did*** matter. Everyone else thought so and that made it an issue. But, we were in love. Race became another thing that we could talk about. See, when you're in love, you don't ignore things about the other person. You admire each aspect of them. You cherish them.

And it was love. I'd never been in love before, but if this wasn't it, I didn't even want to know how giddy I'd be when the real thing came along. We'd spend time in the park; watch old M*A *S*H* re-runs; talk all night and then call in sick so we could let the moments linger. Ricky loved me. No doubts. No questions asked. Which is why, when my best friend Gina approaches me with her patented, “We gotta talk,” I could hardly believe that the topic was my so-called "dysfunction."

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GINA: What are you thinking? Do you have any idea what people are saying about you?

SUSAN: Let me guess. I'm betraying my race, slumming it, got jungle fever, and if I said the" N" word, I could list a string of adjectives created from it. Who cares?

GINA: Fine. Who cares what they're saying. Here's what I, you best friend, am telling you. Get out. Please. Susan, it's just not right. I'm no Klansman or anything, but I just don't think you know what you're doing . . .

SUSAN: God, Gina. I expected this from my parents. But you? It's 1995. No. You understand me. It's 1995.

You know how Bryan Adams sings about the Summer of '69 being the best time of his life? The Summer of '95. It was the best time for me. Despite it all, Ricky and I had fallen deeply in love. So deeply, that when I discovered I was pregnant, I was honestly overjoyed. Really. I told Ricky about it. He agreed; it was a blessing.

RICKY: Guess I'm going to have to make you legit.

SUSAN: Are you asking what I think you are?

RICKY: Not yet. I gotta wait and do it up special. But don't make any plans at New Years.

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There I was. A not-yet-wed pregnant woman in a relationship no one approves of, and yet all I could say was Sweetheart, that sounds wonderful. I was about to get married. Be a mom. Do it all. Wow. No turning back now. I thought of my father. No turning back now. I thought of Gina, my church, my coworkers. No turning back now.

August was spent in a mad rush between doctor's appointments, titanic shopping sprees, and stacks of catalogs to be perused in the late afternoons, and, oh yes, stealing moments with Ricky. I was eating for two. Shopping for a wedding. It was exhausting. I collapsed in bed - thoroughly spent; thoroughly satisfied.

Then one morning in early September, Ricky went out early to get doughnuts. Chocolate long johns. A dozen. We were skipping work again. I loved it. He left at 7:30.

8:00: Ricky hadn't returned. 8:30: nothing. 9:00: nothing. I called his friends, my friends, his family - no one had seen him. At 9:43, the call came. I knew something awful had happened. I couldn't pick up the phone, so I just listened to the machine.

Ricky was dead. Dead. Dead. It was a car crash. There was no brake fluid. He had slammed into a tree. It

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appeared that the car had been tampered with. And that was it.

And you know I could have been thinking a million things like my poor Ricky, should I call his parents? Should I go see him? What do I do? But instead, all I could think was: he was driving my car. It was supposed to be me. It was meant for me. It should have been me. I mean, that's kind of tough to grapple with. Did Ricky die because of lack of brake fluid and the placement of a tree? Or did he die because he loved me? Because someone didn't approve. I mean, it couldn't have been that, right? I mean, it's 1995.

Two events shaped my October: the crash was found not to be an accident, and I lost my baby in its first trimester. The revelation of the crash just confirmed what I knew all along; the revelation of the baby was a strange mix of feelings between this black hole of emotion and an unsettling sense of relief. I felt this incredible void because I'd lost the last part of Ricky I had left. I felt relief that our child would never have to experience the hatred people felt for his Black father, merely hoping for a few seconds of peace.

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I became a loner. I didn't see family. I didn't see Gina. I quit my job. But, I spent my time thinking of these people, asking myself one question: Who did it? Who took it all away?

In the end, all I had was the moments. Stolen moments of one summer with a man. A Black man, but a man just the same. Moments in the park. Moments holding hands. Moments forever remembered in black and white.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Janet O'Neill
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AWARD HISTORY

2004 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
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KS State Qualifier

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